THE SCAM ECOSYSTEM

Graphic by **NILANJAN DAS** | *Text by* **KAUSHIK DEKA**



PROCURING SIM CARDS AND CREATING ACCOUNTS

International scammers operate through local agents who procure SIM cards and use them to open bank accounts. Often low-income individuals are persuaded to open personal or corporate accounts under fake names. These "mule accounts", whose credentials are controlled by scammers, are later used to collect/ transfer money



COLLECTING VICTIM DATA

Personal data, primarily from Aadhaar cards, is illegally sourced from hotels, telecom companies, or accidental leaks. Scammers spend weeks studying this info



RECRUITMENT DRIVE

Fraudsters lure job-seekers with promises of high-paying jobs in countries like Laos, Cambodia, Malaysia, Vietnam and Myanmar. Many fall into the trap

TRAPPING RECRUITS

Once the job aspirants arrive in Southeast Asia, their passports are confiscated. They are confined in prison-like conditions and forced into cyber scams. Some comply willingly, while others are subjected to torture





TRAINING FOR THE SCAM

Scammers are trained to impersonate police officers, government officials and even judges. They are taught psychological manipulation, acting skills and language accents to target victims from their home states



CREATING FAKE ENVIRONMENTS

Elaborate backdrops simulating police stations, courtrooms and other government offices are set up for video calls to fool victims

INITIAL CONTACT

The initial call to the victim may come from India or abroad, typically via WhatsApp, using SIM boxes with multiple SIM cards that bypass official gateways and convert VoIP calls–often from Southeast Asia–into local ones. Here, the victim is informed of the 'crime' and told to join a video call

